

Word family: **early / earlier / earliest**

Base word: early

Part of speech: mainly **adjective** and **adverb**

Related forms:

early (adj.) — 早的；初期的；早期的

early (adv.) — 早地；提早

earlier — 更早；較早

earliest — 最早

early on — 在早期；一開始

early in — 在.....早期

early days — 初期；起步階段

early stage — 早期階段

early years — 早年

early warning — 預警

early adopter — 早期採用者

early bird — 早起的人；早到的人

the early hours — 凌晨時分

at the earliest — 最早也要.....

earlier than expected — 比預期早

early in life — 人生早期

early in the morning — 一大早

Meaning in this passage

> I also began **waking up earlier** and doing the hardest tasks first...

Here, **earlier** means:

at an earlier time than before — 比以前更早

The speaker changed their routine so that they woke up sooner in the morning.

中文翻譯：

我也開始**早一點起床**，並先處理最困難的事情。

So here:

earlier = 在時間上比原本、以前或另一個時間點更早

1. **early (時間早) — 早 ; 提早**

This is the core sense behind your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I began waking up **earlier**.

我開始**早一點起床**。

Practice 2

> I arrived **early** for the meeting.

我**提早**到了會議場地。

Practice 3

> She went to bed **early**.

她**很早**便上床睡覺。

MCQ-ready definition:

early = 在預期、正常或通常時間之前

2. **early morning — 清晨 ; 一大早**

Practice 1

> I do my best work in the **early morning**.

我在**清晨**工作效率最高。

Practice 2

> We left in the **early morning**.

我們在**一大早**出發。

MCQ-ready definition:

early morning = 一天中較早的早晨時段

3. **early in the morning — 一大早**

Practice 1

> I usually exercise **early in the morning**.

我通常**一大早**做運動。

Practice 2

> The streets are quiet **early in the morning**.

清晨時分街上很安靜。

MCQ-ready definition:

early in the morning = 在早晨較早的時間

4. **arrive early / leave early — 提早到 / 早走**

Practice 1

> We arrived **early**.

我們**提早到了**。

Practice 2

> I had to leave **early**.

我不得不**提早離開**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early = 比原定、通常或預期時間早

5. **early (初期的) — 早期的 ; 初期的**

A major separate adjective sense.

Practice 1

> The project is still in its **early stages**.

這個項目仍處於**早期階段**。

Practice 2

> In the **early part of the course**, we focused on basic skills.

在課程的**初期**，我們集中學習基本技巧。

MCQ-ready definition:

early = 發生在某段時期、過程或發展的開始部分

6. **early stage — 早期階段**

Practice 1

> The idea is still at an **early stage**.

這個想法仍處於**早期階段**。

Practice 2

> Problems are easier to fix at an **early stage**.

問題在**早期階段**較容易處理。

MCQ-ready definition:

early stage = 某個過程或發展剛開始不久的階段

7. **early days — 初期；剛起步時**

Practice 1

> It's still **early days**.

現在仍是**初期階段**。

Practice 2

> In the **early days** of the company, only five people worked there.

公司**成立初期**只有五名員工。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****early days = 某件事剛開始發展的時期****

8. ****early years — 早年；早期歲月****

Practice 1

> She spent her ****early years**** in the countryside.

她的****早年生活****在鄉郊度過。

Practice 2

> His ****early years**** shaped his personality.

他的****早年經歷****塑造了他的性格。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****early years = 某人生命或某組織發展中較早的一段時期****

9. ****early in life — 人生早期****

Practice 1

> She developed good habits ****early in life****.

她在人生****很早期****便養成良好習慣。

Practice 2

> Learning this skill ****early in life**** can be helpful.

在人生****早期****學會這項技能很有幫助。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****early in life = 在年紀較小或人生較早階段****

10. ****early on — 一開始；在早期****

A very useful discourse expression.

Practice 1

> I realized **early on** that I needed better time management.

我**很早便意識到**自己需要更好的時間管理。

Practice 2

> The team faced problems **early on**.

團隊在**初期**便遇到問題。

MCQ-ready definition:

early on = 在某件事開始後不久

11. **earlier** (較早 ; 更早) — 較早 ; 之前

This is the comparative form used in your passage.

Practice 1

> I started getting up **earlier**.

我開始**更早起床**。

Practice 2

> She arrived **earlier than me**.

她比我**更早到**。

MCQ-ready definition:

earlier = 比另一個時間點更早

12. **earlier than expected** — 比預期早

Practice 1

> The meeting ended **earlier than expected**.

會議**比預期早**結束。

Practice 2

> She recovered **earlier than expected**.

她**比預期更早**康復。

MCQ-ready definition:

earlier than expected = 發生時間比原先預測更早

13. **earlier today / this week / this year — 今天較早時 / 本週較早時 / 今年較早時**

Practice 1

> I spoke to him **earlier today**.

我**今天較早時**和他談過。

Practice 2

> The issue came up **earlier this week**.

這個問題在**本週較早時候**出現過。

MCQ-ready definition:

earlier + time period = 在目前所指時段中的較早時候

14. **earlier (以前的 ; 之前的) — 較早的 ; 之前的**

Adjectival use.

Practice 1

> In an **earlier version**, the ending was different.

在**較早的版本**中，結局不同。

Practice 2

> My **earlier work** was less organised.

我**早期的作品**沒有那麼有條理。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****earlier = 在現在所比較的事物之前存在或發生的****

15. ****earliest (最早的 ; 最早) — 最早****

Practice 1

> What is the ****earliest**** time you can arrive?

你最早可以甚麼時間到？

Practice 2

> This is one of his ****earliest works****.

這是他****最早期的作品****之一。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****earliest = 在所有比較對象中時間最早****

16. ****at the earliest — 最早也要.....****

Practice 1

> The work will be finished on Friday ****at the earliest****.

這項工作****最早也要星期五****才完成。

Practice 2

> I can arrive at six ****at the earliest****.

我****最早也只能六時****到。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****at the earliest = 不可能早於所說的時間****

17. ****early warning — 預警 ; 早期警告****

A major compound.

Practice 1

> The system provides an **early warning** of possible problems.

系統會對可能出現的問題提供**預警**。

Practice 2

> These symptoms can be an **early warning sign**.

這些症狀可能是**早期警號**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early warning = 在問題真正發生或惡化之前提供的警告

18. **early warning sign** — 早期警號；早期徵兆

Practice 1

> Constant tiredness can be an **early warning sign** of overwork.

持續疲倦可能是過度工作的**早期警號**。

Practice 2

> We ignored the **early warning signs**.

我們忽略了那些**早期徵兆**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early warning sign = 問題尚未完全發展前已經出現的跡象

19. **early adopter** — 早期採用者

A common technology/business expression.

Practice 1

> He is an **early adopter** of new technology.

他是新科技的**早期採用者**。

Practice 2

> **Early adopters** often try products before most people do.

早期採用者通常比大部分人更早試用新產品。

MCQ-ready definition:

early adopter = 在新科技、產品或做法剛出現時便開始使用的人

20. **early bird — 早起的人；早到的人**

Practice 1

> I'm an **early bird**.

我是個**早起的人**。

Practice 2

> She's always the **early bird** at meetings.

她開會時總是**最早到的人**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early bird = 習慣早起或比別人早到的人

21. **early-bird offer / discount — 早鳥優惠**

A common commercial extension.

Practice 1

> We booked early to get the **early-bird discount**.

我們提早預訂以享用**早鳥優惠**。

Practice 2

> **Early-bird tickets** are cheaper.

****早鳥票**較便宜。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****early-bird offer = 給予提早購買、預訂或報名者的優惠****

22. ****the early hours — 凌晨時分****

A distinct time expression.

Practice 1

> We worked into ****the early hours****.

我們工作到****凌晨時分****。

Practice 2

> The party continued until ****the early hours of the morning****.

派對持續到****凌晨****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****the early hours = 午夜後到天亮前的凌晨時間****

23. ****early evening / early afternoon — 傍晚較早時 / 下午早段****

Practice 1

> I'll call you in the ****early evening****.

我會在****傍晚較早時****打給你。

Practice 2

> The rain should stop by ****early afternoon****.

雨應該在****下午早段****前後停。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****early + part of day = 該時段開始不久的部分****

24. **early (提前發生) — 提早發生的**

Practice 1

> We had an **early lunch**.

我們**提早吃了午飯**。

Practice 2

> The team made an **early start**.

團隊**提早開始**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early = 比通常或原定時間更早發生

25. **early start — 早開始 ; 早起**

Practice 1

> We need an **early start** tomorrow.

我們明天要**一早開始 / 早起**。

Practice 2

> An **early start** helped us avoid traffic.

提早出發令我們避開了交通擠塞。

MCQ-ready definition:

early start = 在一天或活動較早的時間開始

26. **early retirement — 提早退休**

Practice 1

> He took **early retirement**.

他選擇了**提早退休**。

Practice 2

> The company offered an **early retirement** package.

公司提供**提前退休方案**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early retirement = 在一般或原定退休年齡前退休

27. **early release — 提早釋放 / 提早推出**

Context determines the exact meaning.

Practice 1

> He was granted **early release** from prison.

他獲准**提早出獄**。

Practice 2

> The studio announced an **early release** of the film.

電影公司宣布影片會**提早上映 / 推出**。

MCQ-ready definition:

early release = 比原定時間更早被釋放、推出或發布

Important distinction 1: **early vs soon**

early

earlier than normal, expected, or scheduled.

soon

after a short period from now/then.

> I arrived early.

> 我提早到。

> I'll arrive soon.

> 我很快會到。

Completely different time reference.

Important distinction 2: **early** vs **before**

early

evaluates timing as relatively early.

before

simply expresses sequence.

> I arrived before Kevin.

> 我比 Kevin 早到。

This does not necessarily mean I arrived **early** for the meeting.

Important distinction 3: **early** vs **earlier**

early

base form.

> I wake up early.

我早起。

earlier

comparative.

> I wake up earlier now.

我現在比以前早起。

Your passage needs **earlier** because it compares the new habit with the speaker's previous routine.

Important distinction 4: **earlier vs previously**

earlier

emphasizes earlier time.

previously

emphasizes something being true before now.

> I saw him earlier.

> 我較早前見過他。

> I previously worked there.

> 我以前在那裏工作。

They overlap sometimes, but not always.

Important distinction 5: **early vs premature**

early

simply before normal/expected time.

premature

too early, often undesirably.

> early decision

> 早些作出的決定

> premature decision

> 過早作出的決定

So **early** is neutral; **premature** often implies poor timing.

Important distinction 6: **early vs timely**

early

before normal/expected time.

timely

at the right/useful time.

Something can be early but not timely.

> an early apology

> 很早作出的道歉

> a timely apology

> 在最合適時機作出的道歉

Important distinction 7: **early stage vs beginning**

beginning

the actual start point.

early stage

period shortly after the start.

So something can no longer be at the exact beginning but still be in an early stage.

Important distinction 8: **early days**

> It's early days.

does not simply mean "it is early in the day."

It means:

事情還在初期，現在下定論還太早

This is highly idiomatic.

Important distinction 9: **early bird literal vs commercial**

Person:

- > an early bird
- > 早起 / 早到的人

Commercial:

- > early-bird discount
- > 給提早購買者的優惠

The second develops from the familiar idea that people who act early gain an advantage.

Important distinction 10: ****the early hours****

This normally means:

****凌晨****

not “早上的幾個小時.”

- > at two in the morning = in the early hours

Very useful learner trap.

Important distinction 11: ****early work can mean two things****

- > my early work

usually means:

****我職業 / 創作生涯早期的作品****

not:

- > 我早上完成的工作

Context decides.

Important distinction 12: ****early warning****

This does not simply mean a warning given early in the day.

It means:

在危險 / 問題真正發生前提早出現的警告

Family-extension note

Early has one broad semantic core:

nearer to the beginning of a time period, sequence, or development than usual or than another reference point

That branches into:

1. **clock time**

- * wake up early
- * arrive early

2. **comparison**

- * earlier
- * earliest

3. **period/development**

- * early stage
- * early days
- * early years

4. **advance timing**

- * early warning
- * early release
- * early retirement

5. **people/behaviour**

- * early bird
- * early adopter

6. **special time expression**

* the early hours

For your passage, the exact branch is:

earlier = at an earlier morning time than before

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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early	早；提早	before normal time
wake up early	早起	morning timing
arrive early	提早到	before scheduled time
early morning	清晨	beginning of morning
early stage	早期階段	beginning of development
early days	初期	just beginning
early years	早年	beginning period
early in life	人生早期	young stage
early on	一開始；早期	soon after beginning
earlier	較早；更早	comparative
earlier today	今天較早時	previous time
earlier version	較早版本	previous form
earliest	最早	superlative
at the earliest	最早也要	no sooner than
early warning	預警	advance warning
early warning sign	早期警號	early indication
early adopter	早期採用者	adopts new things early
early bird	早起 / 早到的人	acts early
early-bird discount	早鳥優惠	reward for early action
the early hours	凌晨時分	after midnight
early start	早開始；提早出發	begin early
early retirement	提早退休	before normal age
early release	提早釋放 / 推出	before scheduled time

For your original sentence

> I also began waking up **earlier** and doing the hardest tasks first, while my mind was still fresh.

Here:

earlier = 比以前的起床時間更早，而不是單純表示「很早」

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 我也開始**早一點起床**，並先處理最困難的事情，因為那時候我的頭腦還最清醒。

The cleanest contrast is:

> **early** = 早

> **earlier** = **比某個參考時間更早**

> **earliest** = 最早

And in this sentence, **earlier** specifically compares the speaker's **new morning routine with their old one**.